STORYBOARD AI

Product Brief & Build Package

Turn your screenplay into an editable, cinematic storyboard in minutes.

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1. Product Requirements Document (PRD)

1.1 Product Overview

Product Name (working): Storyboard AI

Positioning: Turn a screenplay into an editable, cinematic storyboard in minutes.

Product Category: Workflow tool for directorial clarity — not an image generation toy.

1.2 Problem Statement

Creative teams can generate individual images with AI, but they still cannot reliably transform a screenplay into a coherent, reviewable storyboard that includes usable shot logic, visual continuity, and export-ready presentation. Existing tools either produce disconnected images or require extensive manual shot planning, costing teams hours of work that delays pitches, pre-production reviews, and client presentations.

1.3 Product Thesis

The input text is not the product. The images are not the product. The product is structured cinematic interpretation with controllable visual output. The system must generate three artifacts per project to deliver real value:

1. Scene map — what happens in the story
2. Shot plan — how to show it cinematically
3. Storyboard panels — what it looks like, with continuity

If any one of these layers is missing, the app degrades into either a text parser or an inconsistent image generator — neither of which solves the core problem.

1.4 Core Promise

Convert screenplay text into scene structure, a shot plan with visible rationale, and storyboard panels with style consistency and continuity — all editable and exportable.

1.5 V1 Goals

- Users get to a usable first storyboard fast (target: under 10 minutes for a short script)
- Every panel has a visible rationale — users understand why the system chose each shot
- Users can edit individual panels without regenerating the entire project
- Output is presentable enough to export and share with clients or collaborators

1.6 V1 Feature Scope

Feature	Description	Priority
Screenplay input	Paste or upload screenplay text	P0
Scene detection	Auto-parse scenes, sluglines, dialogue, action	P0
Beat extraction	Identify key beats with intent, emotion, action level	P0
Shot plan generation	AI-generated shot list with type, framing, rationale	P0
Style selection	Project-level visual style choice (set once)	P0
Storyboard rendering	Generate panels from shot plan + style + continuity	P0
Per-panel regeneration	Regen a single panel without affecting neighbors	P0
Shot-type editing	Change shot type on any panel and re-render	P0
Panel reordering	Drag to reorder panels within a scene	P0
PDF export	Export storyboard as a presentable PDF	P0
Continuity lock improvements	Stronger character/location memory across panels	P1
Panel notes & review states	Add notes; mark panels as approved/needs-rework	P1
Enhanced export formatting	Branded themes, title pages, panel density controls	P1
Prose input	Accept freeform story/narrative text	P2
Collaboration	Multi-user editing, comments, approvals	P2
Animatics	Timeline-based panel sequencing with timing	P2
API / integrations	Plugin ecosystem, external tool connections	P2

1.7 Explicit Non-Goals (V1)

- Prose / freeform story input (separate parsing problem; dilutes V1 accuracy)
- Collaboration features (adds complexity before core is validated)

- Animatic / video generation
- Mobile-first app
- Voice or audio generation
- Full character design studio
- Community templates or marketplace

1.8 UX Architecture

The core workspace uses a three-pane layout designed to feel like a director's control room, not an AI prompt box:

Pane	Content	Purpose	Key Controls
Left	Script / Scene Navigator	Show source material and scene structure	Scene list, parsing status, character/location detection
Center	Shot Planner	Display directorial decisions and rationale	Beat cards, shot list, shot type, pacing, edit controls
Right	Storyboard Canvas	Show visual output with continuity	Panel grid, regen, reorder, variant compare, continuity badge

Visual priority order: active storyboard panel first, shot list logic second, source script context third. Users buy the visual result, but trust comes from the logic beside it.

1.9 Panel Metadata (Trust Layer)

Every generated panel must display inspectable metadata. This is non-negotiable — if users cannot see why the system made a choice, trust collapses. Each panel shows:

- Source scene and source beat
- Shot type and camera angle
- Purpose / intent of the shot
- Continuity state (locked / at risk / changed by regen)
- Rationale for the shot selection
- Regenerate and edit controls

1.10 Golden Path (V1 User Flow)

1. Create a new project

2. Choose visual style (once, at project creation)
3. Upload or paste screenplay
4. Review auto-detected scene structure and beat extraction
5. Select a scene to work on
6. Inspect the AI-generated shot list and rationale
7. Generate storyboard panels for the scene
8. Tweak individual shots or regenerate specific panels as needed
9. Export the storyboard as a PDF

1.11 Success Metrics

Activation

- Primary activation metric: user exports a storyboard within first session
- Screenplay uploaded → first shot plan generated → first scene rendered → first board exported

Product Quality

- Percentage of panels accepted without regeneration
- Average regenerations per scene (lower is better)
- Shot-plan approval score from target users
- Continuity failure rate per scene
- Percentage of edits resolved with local rerun only (no cascading regen)

Retention

- 7-day return rate
- Second project started; second export completed
- Percentage of returning users who bring a new script (not just reopen old work)

Revenue

- Free-to-paid conversion rate after first export
- Average renders per paid project
- Cost per successfully exported project
- Team-seat expansion rate for agency accounts

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2. Ideal Customer Profile (ICP)

2.1 Primary Buyer: Agencies & Creative Teams

Attribute	Detail
Who	Creative directors, producers, and account leads at advertising agencies, production companies, and brand creative teams
Core Pain	Need client-facing storyboards fast; current process requires manual shot planning or expensive storyboard artists with multi-day turnarounds
Key Behaviors	Work on multiple projects concurrently; present boards in pitch decks and review meetings; iterate based on client feedback
Buying Signal	Speed and presentation quality; willingness to pay for tools that reduce turnaround from days to minutes
ACV Potential	High — team seats, branded exports, volume usage
Tolerance for AI	High, provided output is editable and presentable

2.2 Primary Design Partner: Indie Filmmakers & Directors

Attribute	Detail
Who	Independent directors, storyboard-heavy creators, and pre-visualization specialists
Core Pain	Already think in scenes and shots; need affordable previsualization without a full storyboard artist or previs studio
Key Behaviors	Work from screenplays; care deeply about shot logic, pacing, and framing; will scrutinize cinematic accuracy
Value to Product	Provide the most specific, brutal, and useful feedback on shot logic and continuity; strong case-study potential
ACV Potential	Moderate — individual Pro subscriptions; some may convert teams
Strategic Role	Keep the product honest; agencies pay, filmmakers ensure the core brain works for real production

2.3 Deprioritized Segments (Not V1 Targets)

Segment	Reason to Deprioritize
Hobby writers / casual creators	Weak storyboard need; low willingness to pay; feedback is less production-relevant
AI art enthusiasts	Interested in generation novelty, not workflow; risks pulling product toward “content gimmick” territory
Content creators / YouTubers	Good scale market for later; but if targeted too early, drags product positioning away from professional tooling
Screenwriters (standalone)	Useful but weaker initial buyer; becomes viable when positioned as pitch enhancement in a later phase

2.4 ICP Strategy: Buyer + Evangelist Model

The go-to-market pairs two ICP roles for maximum effectiveness:

- Buyer (Agencies): have budget, need fast turnaround, care about polish — drive revenue
- Evangelist / Design Partner (Indie Directors): strongest workflow pain, provide brutal feedback, produce compelling case studies — drive product quality and credibility

This dual model ensures the product is both commercially viable and genuinely useful.

3. Monetization & Pricing Hypothesis

3.1 Pricing Philosophy

Sell workflow value; meter render cost. The expensive part of the system is image rendering. The valuable part is directorial acceleration — the speed and clarity of going from script to presentable board. Pricing must charge for the valuable part while containing the expensive part.

Rule: do not offer unlimited generation at a flat subscription rate. That creates margin risk if inference costs spike and trains users to waste renders.

3.2 Tier Structure

Feature	Free	Pro	Team / Studio	Enterprise	Add-Ons
Projects	1	Unlimited	Unlimited	Custom	—
Panels / month	Capped (low)	Monthly credit allotment	Higher credit pool	Custom	Extra credit packs
Watermark	Yes	No	No	No	—
Style presets	Basic only	Full library	Full + brand kits	Custom kits	Alt-style passes
Export	Basic PDF	Standard PDF	Branded PDF + themes	White-label	High-res export
Panel editing	Limited	Full	Full	Full	—
Seats	1	1	Multiple	Org-wide	—
Shared workspaces	—	—	Yes	Yes	—

Review / approval workflow	—	—	Yes	Yes	—
Continuity controls	Basic	Standard	Premium	Premium	Premium mode
Priority generation	—	—	Yes	Yes	—

3.3 Recommended Early Model

Subscription + usage credits is the recommended model for launch. It provides predictable SaaS revenue while protecting against inference cost spikes. Per-project packs and agency annual plans are secondary pricing experiments to test.

3.4 Premium Design-Led Features (Margin Drivers)

Extra image generations are increasingly commodity. The real margin lives in presentation power and control:

- Branded export themes and title pages
- Clean presentation mode and shareable review links
- Side-by-side version comparison for alternate panels
- Premium continuity lock controls
- Shot rationale visibility in exported documents
- Client-facing comment-safe view

4. Technical Architecture

4.1 Architecture Principle

The system is a stateful pipeline, not a single monolithic prompt. Each stage produces structured, inspectable output that feeds the next. Edits trigger localized reruns — not full-project regeneration.

4.2 Core Pipeline

The pipeline has five stages, each with clear inputs and outputs:

Stage	Action	Input	Output
1. Ingest	Parse screenplay structure	Raw screenplay text	Scenes, dialogue, action, sluglines, characters, locations, props, tone
2. Interpret	Extract beats from scenes	Parsed scenes	Beats tagged with intent, emotional weight, action level, key subjects, continuity requirements
3. Direct	Generate shot recommendations	Tagged beats	Shot list: type, framing, angle, camera intent, visual focus, rationale, continuity notes
4. Visualize	Render storyboard panels	Shot specs + style profile + continuity state	Panels with metadata and source links
5. Edit Loop	Handle user modifications	User changes to shot/panel/order	Only affected nodes re-run; no full-project regen unless explicitly requested

4.3 Core Data Objects

The system operates on these persistent objects within a project:

Object	Role
Project	Top-level container; owns all other objects
Script	Raw screenplay text and parsing state
Scene	A discrete unit of action at one location/time
Beat	A meaningful moment within a scene (action, emotional shift, dialogue exchange)
Shot	A cinematic recommendation for how to show a beat
Panel	The rendered visual for a shot, with metadata
Style Profile	Visual style parameters applied project-wide
Continuity State	Persistent memory of character appearance, location geometry, props, and time-of-day across panels
Character / Location Cards	Reference descriptions for consistent rendering of recurring elements

4.4 Biggest Technical Risk: Control Drift

The primary technical risk is not image quality — it is control drift. This manifests as:

- Shot specifies close-up, but image renders a medium shot

- Same character mutates appearance every few panels
- Location geometry changes between shots in the same scene
- Tone and lighting shift inconsistently
- Regenerating one panel breaks continuity with its neighbors

Mitigation: the architecture enforces a strict state chain — story state → shot state → render state — with persistent project memory. Edits propagate downward through the chain, and re-renders inherit continuity context from adjacent panels.

5. Execution Roadmap

Stage 1: Prove the Brain

Goal: Verify the system can make sane cinematic decisions.

Build

- Screenplay ingest and scene parsing
- Beat extraction engine
- Shot recommendation engine
- One-scene storyboard render
- Per-panel regeneration with neighbor preservation
- Style lock at project level

Exit Criteria

- 3–5 real scripts processed end-to-end
- Shot plans rated “useful” by at least 3 target users from the ICP
- Per-panel regen preserves neighboring continuity often enough to be trusted
- First-scene output is presentable, not just technically complete

Stage 2: Prove the Workflow

Goal: Confirm users can actually work inside the tool.

Build

- Three-pane workspace UI
- Editable shot list with rationale display

- Panel reorder and shot-type editing
- Panel metadata visibility (trust layer)
- PDF export

Exit Criteria

- Users go from screenplay to exported board without handholding
- Edits feel local, not destructive
- Users understand why each panel exists
- At least 50% of alpha users export something in their first session

Stage 3: Prove the Business

Goal: Validate willingness to pay and sustainable economics.

Build

- Project persistence and storage
- Usage tracking and billing infrastructure
- Credits + subscription packaging
- Cleaner presentation and export modes

Exit Criteria

- Multiple users ask to keep using the product after trial ends
- Paid beta users tolerate usage-based limits
- Export/share behavior repeats across multiple projects
- Unit economics (cost per exported project) are survivable

Stage 4: Scale Features (Post-Validation)

- Prose / freeform story input
- Collaboration (multi-user editing, comments, approvals)
- Animatic timeline
- Style kits and brand templates
- API and plugin integrations

6. Risk Register

#	Risk	Symptom	Mitigation
1	Shot logic feels generic	Boards feel like random film-school clichés rather than intentional direction	Human-reviewed shot heuristics; genre presets; explicit rationale per shot; design-partner feedback loops
2	Continuity breaks on regen	Characters, props, framing, or settings mutate across panels within the same scene	Persistent continuity state object; scene memory; localized reruns only; character/location cards
3	Users don't trust the system	"Why did it do that?" — no visible logic behind panel choices	Expose source beat, shot type, rationale, continuity notes, and editable controls on every panel
4	Pretty output, weak utility	Users say "cool" but not "I'd use this on a real project"	Recruit agencies/directors early; optimize for exportability and review workflow, not visual novelty
5	Cost structure collapses	High render usage destroys SaaS economics; margin erodes as usage grows	Subscription + credits model; meter premium operations; optimize regen locality to reduce unnecessary renders
6	Scope creep	Prose, collaboration, animatics, mobile, API — all attempted too early, fragmenting the core	Screenplay-only V1; every new feature must protect the core loop: parse → plan → render → edit → export
7	Overly literal visual interpretation	System renders exactly what the text says rather than interpreting it cinematically	Direction layer must add cinematic intent beyond literal text; genre presets inform visual interpretation

7. Go / No-Go Gates

The product must not expand to prose input, collaboration, or animatics until all five of the following conditions are met:

Gate	Condition	Validation Method
1	Shot plans are respected by real target users (agencies and directors)	User interviews + approval scoring

2	Scene continuity survives panel edits without cascading failures	Automated continuity tests + user reports
3	Users export storyboards without coaching or hand-holding	Funnel analytics: paste-to-export rate
4	At least some users say they would use this tool on real production work	Post-session surveys + repeat-project tracking
5	Unit economics are survivable (cost per exported project within margin targets)	Cost accounting per project

If these five gates are not passed, adding features is decorating failure. The sequence matters: prove the brain, then the workflow, then the business.

8. Alpha Validation Plan

8.1 Prototype Scope

The first prototype is not a polished product. It is a test of whether the core brain works:

- Upload a screenplay
- Parse scenes automatically
- Generate a beat list
- Generate a shot list with rationale
- Render one scene only as storyboard panels
- Support: change shot type, regenerate one panel, preserve style across the sequence

8.2 Alpha Cohorts

Group A: Agencies

5–10 agency contacts. Validate commercial viability.

- Would you use this for internal or client ideation?
- Is the output presentable enough for a client meeting?
- Does this save real hours compared to your current process?

Group B: Indie Directors / Storyboard Users

5–10 indie filmmakers. Validate cinematic quality.

- Are the shot recommendations sane and useful?
- Does the pacing feel directed or generic?
- Can you actually steer the output when it’s wrong?

8.3 Success Gates for Alpha

- Users export boards without hand-holding
- Per-panel edits don't wreck neighboring panels
- Shot logic is called "useful" or better by real professionals
- At least some users say "I'd use this on a real project"

The bar is "useful," not "cool" or "interesting."

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9. UX Blueprint & Key Screens

9.1 Five Experience States

The user moves through five states during a session. If the user cannot feel this progression, the product feels random:

State	Label	User Action	System Response
1	Ingest	Paste or upload screenplay	Accept and prepare for parsing
2	Understand	Review detected scenes and beats	Show parsed structure with characters, locations, tone
3	Direct	Inspect and edit the shot plan	Display shot list with rationale and controls
4	Visualize	Review storyboard panels	Render panels with continuity and metadata
5	Present	Export or share the board	Generate clean, branded PDF or review link

9.2 Key Screen Specifications

A. Project Creation

Purpose: set constraints early so output is coherent. Fields include project name, screenplay upload/paste, style selection, genre preset, and output mode (rough / polished). Style is chosen here once and not scattered throughout the workspace.

B. Workspace (Three-Pane Layout)

The primary working screen. Left pane shows the script and scene navigator. Center pane shows the shot planner with beat cards, rationale, and edit controls. Right pane shows the

storyboard canvas with panel grid, regen controls, reorder capability, variant comparison, and continuity badges.

C. Panel Inspector

Clicking a panel opens a side inspector showing source scene, source beat, shot type, camera angle, purpose, continuity notes, style profile, regen controls, change-shot-type control, and variant history. This is where trust lives.

D. Export Screen

Designed as presentation prep, not a file download afterthought. Controls include PDF layout, title page toggle, panel density, notes on/off, branding and theme selection, and client-safe clean mode. Export is the moment the product becomes worth money.

9.3 Design System Direction

- Product personality: cinematic, precise, premium, production-ready
- Not: playful AI toy, comic generator, generic SaaS dashboard
- Dark workspace by default with strong contrast
- Sharp panel framing; restrained accent color
- Typography: editorial feel, not startup-template generic
- Aggressive use of whitespace around panels and controls

9.4 Trust UX Check

V1 design passes only if a user can answer these four questions instantly at any point during a session:

1. What scene am I in?
2. Why does this panel exist?
3. What can I change without breaking everything?
4. How do I export this cleanly?

10. Competitive Moat

The moat is not “we use AI.” Image generation is commodity and becoming more commoditized by the week. The defensible differentiation is:

Moat Layer	Why It Matters
Screenplay parsing quality	Accurate extraction of scenes, beats, characters, and continuity requirements from industry-standard screenplay format
Beat-to-shot intelligence	Cinematic recommendations that feel directed, not random — the system understands pacing, tension, and camera language
Panel continuity memory	Persistent state that preserves character appearance, location geometry, props, and lighting across panels and scenes
Style locking	Project-wide visual consistency that doesn't drift or require manual correction
Editable production workflow	Users can steer, reorder, and refine output for real production use — not just generate and hope

If the user cannot tell why a panel exists, trust collapses. So every panel carries metadata: shot type, subject, purpose, continuity notes, and source beat. That transparency is part of the moat.

Appendix: Positioning

Primary Positioning Line

"Turn your screenplay into an editable, cinematic storyboard in minutes."

Alternate Options

- From script to shot-planned storyboard, fast.
- AI storyboarding with cinematic logic, not random panels.

Category Framing

This product is a screenplay-to-storyboard workflow tool for agencies and filmmakers, built around shot planning, continuity, and editable outputs. It is not positioned as "generate art," "create comics," or "AI visuals." Those are weaker and cheaper categories.

Governing Principle

We are not selling images. We are selling directorial clarity.